

How Can You Make a Good Name With God?

Public Talk No. 55

Version: v2 focused draft

Target length: 30 minutes including scripture readings

Introduction (05) 2 min

(Warm opening)

Have you ever walked past a garden and noticed a pleasant fragrance before you even saw the flower? You may stop and think, "Where is that coming from?" The flower may be small. It may even be partly hidden among the leaves. But its fragrance has already made an impression.

(Connect gently)

In a similar way, our name carries something. When people hear our name, it may bring thoughts to mind: "That person is honest." "That person is kind." "That person can be trusted." Of course, people do not always see clearly. Sometimes they remember unusual things too. We may try hard for years to build a good reputation, and someone still remembers the one time we tripped while carrying food at a gathering.

(Pause briefly)

But there is one Person whose view of our name matters more than anyone else's: Jehovah.

(State theme)

So today we will consider this important question: How can you make a good name with God? This is not only for those who have served Jehovah for many years. New ones, young ones, and those rebuilding spiritual habits can begin making a good name with Jehovah now.

A Good Name Is Valuable (07) 3 min incl. reading

(Transition to scripture)

Please turn to Proverbs 22:1.

(Read; then pause)

Read Proverbs 22:1.

(Explain simply)

The verse says that a good name is to be chosen rather than great wealth. Many people spend much of life trying to make a name for themselves through money, career, education, popularity, or today, through social media. A person may spend twenty minutes arranging a photo of a cup of coffee so that strangers will think, "What a meaningful life." *Meanwhile, the coffee is getting cold.*

(Bring back focus)

There is nothing wrong with having a good reputation with people. Christians should be honest, dependable, and kind. But human approval is not the highest goal. People's opinions change. Some praise quickly and forget quickly. Jehovah's approval is different. People may see the action, but Jehovah sees the motive. People may forget, but Jehovah remembers.

(Brief support)

Jesus helped us see this in Matthew 6:19, 20 when he encouraged his listeners to store up treasures in heaven. Jehovah's approval is the safest place to invest our life.

(Illustrate with main picture)

Think again of that small flower. Its value is not measured by how many people stop to admire it. Its fragrance is simply what it gives off because of what it is. In the same way, a good name with Jehovah is not mainly built by display. It comes from what we are becoming inside.

(Apply)

So the opening question is not simply, "Do people like me?" The better question is, "What kind of name am I making with Jehovah?" Psalm 15:1, 2 briefly reminds us that Jehovah values integrity, right conduct, and truth in the heart. That means a good name with God is within reach. It is built by ordinary people making faithful choices day after day.

(Transition)

But why should we especially want a good name with God?

Why Make a Good Name With God? (10) 5 min incl. reading

(New main section)

Please turn to Malachi 3:16.

(Read warmly)

Read Malachi 3:16.

(Explain the verse)

Notice Jehovah's response. He pays attention. He listens. Those who fear him and meditate on his name are not invisible to him. The verse speaks of a "book of remembrance." That is a warm expression. Jehovah remembers those who value him.

(Encourage newer ones)

That can be very encouraging, especially for newer ones. A person may think, "I do not know much yet. I still get nervous finding Bible books. Sometimes I turn to the table of contents and hope no one notices." But Jehovah is not looking for someone to impress him with speed. He notices sincerity.

(Develop the same garden picture)

It is like a careful gardener. A gardener may notice a small new shoot long before anyone else sees anything special. To others, it may look like just a tiny green stem. But the gardener sees life. He knows what it can become.

(Say; then pause)

Jehovah notices sincere beginnings.

(Brief support)

Hebrews 11:6 says that Jehovah rewards those earnestly seeking him. So if someone starts to pray, starts to study, starts to attend meetings, or starts to make changes, Jehovah sees more than the outward action. He sees the heart behind it.

(Apply warmly)

People do not always see effort. They may hear one short comment at the meeting, but Jehovah may see the preparation, the prayer, and the courage behind that comment. People may see someone sitting calmly in the Kingdom Hall, but Jehovah may know it took real effort just to come.

(Motive)

Why do we want this good name with God? Not just because we owe Jehovah worship, though we do. Revelation 4:11 reminds us that all things exist because of Jehovah's will. But our main motivation is love. Psalm 116:12 captures the spirit: "What can I repay Jehovah for all the good he has done for me?"

(Transition)

So how can we make a good name with God? The outline gives four practical steps: learn about Jehovah, obey his commandments, imitate his qualities, and pray to him.

How Can You Make a Good Name With God? (15) 16 min incl. readings

1. Learn About Jehovah (15) 4 min incl. reading

(Point one clearly)

Please turn to John 17:3.

(Emphasize knowing)

Read John 17:3.

(Read)

Jesus connected everlasting life with coming to know Jehovah and the one he sent, Jesus Christ.

(Explain)

Knowing Jehovah is more than collecting Bible facts. Facts matter, but the goal is relationship. We are learning what Jehovah loves, what he hates, how he treats people, how he views us, and why his way of life is best.

(Illustrate with main picture)

A person could know many facts about a flower: its name, color, season, and soil. But that is different from leaning close, noticing its fragrance, and appreciating what it adds to the garden. Bible study should be like that. We do not just identify information. We come to appreciate Jehovah himself.

(Brief support)

Psalm 119:97 shows the value of loving and meditating on Jehovah's law. So when we read, we can slow down enough to ask: "What does this teach me about Jehovah? What does this teach me about myself? What does Jehovah want me to do?"

(Apply)

This is encouraging if we are newer or if we are rebuilding spiritual habits. We do not need to understand everything at once. A friendship grows through regular attention. A good name with Jehovah begins to grow as we keep learning about him.

(Transition)

But learning about Jehovah naturally leads to the second step.

2. Obey Jehovah's Commandments (19) 4 min incl. reading

(Reassuring tone)

Please turn to 1 John 5:3.

(Emphasize not burdensome)

Read 1 John 5:3.

(Explain)

This scripture connects love with obedience. If we love Jehovah, we observe his commandments. But the verse also says that his commandments are not burdensome.

(Illustrate once)

At first, Bible standards may feel restrictive. But Jehovah's commands protect life. Think of a fence at a lookout point. The fence is not there to spoil the view. It is there so people can enjoy the view safely. Jehovah's standards may at times say, "Do not go beyond this point." That is not because Jehovah wants to take joy away. It is because he sees dangers we may not see.

(Apply to heart)

This helps us obey with the right spirit. We are not obeying a harsh ruler. We are listening to a loving Father. Psalm 103:14 reminds us that Jehovah knows our limitations, so he is not surprised when imperfect people struggle. But he values sincere effort.

(Practical application)

A good way to apply this is to choose one area of obedience to strengthen. It might be speech, entertainment, honesty, association, or family conduct. Instead of trying to fix everything at once, we might ask, "What is one clean step I can take now to show Jehovah that I want a good name with him?"

(Return to main picture)

Each obedient choice is like another quiet fragrance in the garden. It may be private. Others may not notice. But Jehovah does.

3. Imitate Jehovah's Qualities (23) 3 min incl. reading

(Point three clearly)

Please turn to Psalm 25:4.

(Read as request)

Read Psalm 25:4.

(Explain)

David asked Jehovah to make him know His ways and teach him His paths. That is a humble request. He was not saying, "Jehovah, bless the path I already chose." He was saying, "Teach me your path."

(Develop)

Imitating Jehovah means we want more than outward obedience. We want our thinking and feelings to become closer to his. Amos 5:15 states the point simply: hate what is bad and love what is good. We want Jehovah to train our moral taste.

(Anchor in Jesus briefly)

How do we see Jehovah's qualities clearly? By looking at Jesus. John 14:9 shows that Jesus perfectly reflected his Father. When we see Jesus showing compassion, courage, patience, and loyalty, we are seeing Jehovah's qualities in action.

(Apply)

So when we read about Jesus, we can ask: "How did he treat weak people? How did he respond to pressure? How did he defend Jehovah's name? How can I imitate that today?"

(Return to theme)

A good name with Jehovah is not just about avoiding wrong. It is about becoming the kind of person Jehovah is pleased to remember.

4. Pray to Jehovah (26) 5 min incl. reading

(Personal tone)

Please turn to Philippians 4:6.

(Read calmly)

Read Philippians 4:6.

(Explain)

Jehovah speaks to us through the Bible. We speak to him by means of prayer. A friendship cannot grow if only one person speaks. If someone says, "We are very close friends; I listen to his messages every day, but I never reply," we would probably say, "That friendship needs attention."

(Apply)

Prayer is real communication with Jehovah. Philippians 4:6 tells us to make our petitions known to God. That means we can speak to Jehovah about anxieties, decisions, weaknesses, gratitude, and hopes.

(Reassure)

Some feel awkward at first. They may wonder, "What should I say?" But prayer is not a performance. Jehovah is not listening for impressive vocabulary. He is listening for sincerity. A child does not need polished words to speak to a loving father. The relationship is what matters.

(Brief support)

First Peter 5:7 reminds us that Jehovah cares for us. Psalm 55:22 adds that we can throw our burden on him. So prayer is not a cold formality. It is a way to rely on Jehovah.

(Specific application)

We can pray specifically. Not only, "Please help me be good," but, "Please help me control my speech today." Not only, "Please bless my family," but, "Please help me be patient with this family member." Specific prayers help us see Jehovah's help more clearly.

(Summarize four steps)

So the four steps work together. We learn about Jehovah by listening to him in the Bible. We obey because we trust his wisdom. We imitate his qualities because we love his ways. And we pray because we rely on him.

(Return to main picture)

Those steps are like caring for a garden. Learning gives light. Obedience protects. Imitation shapes growth. Prayer keeps the relationship alive. Over time, something beautiful forms: a name with Jehovah that has a pleasing fragrance.

Act Now to Make a Good Name With God (31) 4 min incl. reading

(Conclusion begins)

So far we have seen that a good name with Jehovah is valuable. Jehovah notices sincere ones. And we can build that good name by learning, obeying, imitating, and praying.

(Short pause)

But when should a person start?

(Transition to scripture)

Please turn to Isaiah 55:6.

(Read with urgency)

Read Isaiah 55:6.

(Explain)

The point is clear: search for Jehovah while he may be found. Do not delay. Sometimes a person may think, "I will draw close to Jehovah later, when life is less busy." But life has a way of staying busy. If we wait until everything is calm, we may wait a long time.

(Compassionate tone)

Someone may also think, "But I have made mistakes. Maybe my name with God is already ruined." Isaiah 1:18 gives hope. Jehovah invited people with serious sins to set matters straight with him. So past mistakes do not have to define the future. A repentant person can take one clean step today.

(Final picture)

Let us return one last time to the garden. A flower may be small and partly hidden, but its fragrance can still be noticed. In the same way, your efforts may feel small: a prayer, a Bible study session, a decision to obey, a quiet act of honesty, a step toward repentance, a meeting attended even when tired.

(Warm questions)

People may not notice all of that. But Jehovah does. So ask yourself: "What does my name mean to Jehovah right now? And what step can I take this week to make that name even better with him?"

(Quiet conviction)

If we learn about Jehovah, obey his commandments, imitate his qualities, and pray to him, we can make a good name with God. And that good name is worth more than anything this world can offer.